

A Field Guide to Quiet Mornings

Notes for the unhurried

Folio Editions • No. II

The First Light

Wake, if you can, before the world insists. The early hour belongs to no one, which is precisely why it can belong to you. The light at this time is thin and silver and forgiving; it does not yet ask anything. Let the kettle do its slow work and stand at the window doing nothing in particular.

A quiet morning is not an empty morning. It is full to the brim with small attentions: the cooling of the tea, the particular grey of the sky, the sound of a single early bird testing the silence. To notice these is not idleness. It is a kind of devotion, and the day repays it.

Bring a book to the table, but do not hurry to open it. Let the morning and the page meet on their own terms. Reading, at this hour, is less an activity than a continuation of the quiet by other means.

On Doing Less

The temptation of every morning is to spend it before it has begun, to load the hours with errands until they sag. Resist, gently. A morning kept half-empty is a vessel that the day may pour itself into. The most useful thing you do before nine o'clock may be to read three pages slowly and forget to check the time.

There is a mathematics to this that the busy will not believe: that less, attended to fully, amounts to more. The page read twice is worth four read once. The walk taken without a destination returns you somewhere you needed to be.

Keep your mornings as you would keep a good book: with a ribbon to mark your place, and no great hurry to reach the end.

A Short Catalogue of Small Joys

The first sip, taken too soon, slightly too hot. The weight of a blanket. A letter from someone who still writes letters. The particular satisfaction of a sentence that says exactly what it means and then stops.

The smell of rain not yet fallen. A cat's decision to sit upon the very book you are reading. The discovery, on the second reading, of a line you had somehow walked past the first time, as one walks past a door in a familiar house and only later wonders what was behind it.

These are not the great joys, and that is the point. The great joys are rare and exhausting. The small ones are inexhaustible, and a quiet morning is the net in which they are most easily caught.

End of the Notes